

Contextual Inquiry Field Notes

LIS 470 — Introduction to Interaction Design

Date: <u>2/27/2026</u>	Time: <u>3:00 PM -ish</u>
Location: <u>The Regent → Kwik trip & Trader Joes</u>	Participant ID: <u>1</u>
Facilitator: <u>Alejandro De La Torre</u>	Note Taker: <u>Angelique Carrillo</u>

Activity Being Observed:

Planning ahead for weekly grocery shopping + executing the trip

Observation Notes

Observations (What you see/hear)	Interpretations (What it might mean)
- Began @ apt: survey fridge + pantry - made grocery list of stuff needed - had a routine for 3 meals/day f/ 7 days - pb + banana toast / overnight oats - fried rice w/ veg + egg - pasta w/ ground beef, beans & veg - shops f/ whatever is needed from that - Usually shops once per week (sunday) - sometimes gets stuff before coming back home; sticks to routines - Lives on Regent; walks to Kwik trip first - gets beef (\$4.79/lb f/ 80/20; otherwise \$6+ @ TJ's or most places) + mushrooms, bell peppers, & onions - carries them to TJ's (does not go back) - why? so doesn't shop around + reminds them what they already have (gets easily distracted & buys too much otherwise) - Used phone f/ bus schedule (Goog Maps) + reusable TJ's canvas bag - Took D-bus to TJ's to avoid long walk (sometimes walks if weather nice + has time) + back home - SNAP: \$291/month ⇒ \$40-50/week - overstimulating TJ's sunday around 11-2pm - Shares fridge ⇒ shops once per week - rarely shops around other than TJ's & Kwik trip - No delivery (esp. TJ's not on instacart + they are bad) - beef subs f/ porken	→ highly optimized routine from trial & error - very systemized planning & shopping - even though price sensitive, time is money sticks to what works - Physical constraints (walk + bus + carrying groceries) shape financial discipline - Environmental constraints (shared fridge w/ roommates + busy) leads to 1/week trips - Over shopping is known behavioral tendency they actively counteract - Emotional regulation strategy motivates routine (same stuff, same time, same plan usually) + reduces cognitive load & decision fatigue

Areas to Document

Use this section to organize detailed observations across the four areas.

ACTIVITY — What is the participant doing? Describe step-by-step actions, sequence, duration.

* detailed above

surveys pantry & fridge → plans weekly meals → derives grocery list from meal plan (10-15 min) → walks to kwik trip to check prices (closest) (<10 min) + gets beef & some veg

→ walks/bus to TJ's w/ kwik trip stuff in bag (10-15 min) → completes remaining shopping @ TJ's (30-45 min) + uses list to stay focused (usually busy) → takes stuff home on bus → organizes & cooks

CONTEXT — Where is this happening? What tools, artifacts, people, environmental factors are present?

- Lives in 2-bedroom apt; 1 fridge, 4 people in apt.
- SNAP EBT user (wisco foodshare)
- Budgets @ 40-50
- Transportation: walk + bus (Vilas/Greenbush neighborhood)
- Trader Joe's & kwik trip
- Phone: notes app + google maps
- Reusable canvas bag
- fridge space + pantry shared ⇒ limits bulk cooking

NEEDS / VALUES — What matters to the participant? What are they trying to achieve?

- Maximize value per dollar + optimize nutrition & cost
- Maintain 3 balanced meals per day (5+ servings fruit & veg + protein)
- minimize overspending + avoid financial stress
- Reduce time spent shopping
- Consistency / routine + minimize cognitive load so easy to do even when stressed
- Use SNAP effectively
- Preserve autonomy (avoid eating out)

ASSUMPTIONS — What beliefs or expectations guide their behavior?

- Trader Joe's is generally cheapest overall (if not in cost then time)
- kwik trip beef is cheaper (yes except maybe Woodman's)
- Walking preferred unless heavy load or bad weather
- DoorDash/Instacart/delivery too expensive
- Routine is more effective than experimentation (buys back time instead of deal hunting)

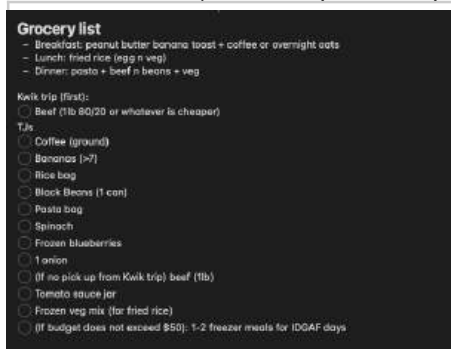
Breakdowns & Successes

BREAKDOWNS (Frustrations, errors, confusion)	SUCCESSSES (What worked well, satisfaction)
• Sundays @ TJ's are overstimulating • unknown tendency to overshop if not careful • physical strain from carrying groceries • limited fridge space • cannot (or rarely) use stores that don't accept EBT (stop & shop, regent mart, etc)	• Highly structured weekly planning system • clear meal-to-list mapping. • strategic store sequencing (kwik trip first) → uses physical weight as behavioral constraint • blends beef + beans to stretch protein cost effectively • strong awareness of price diffs. → SNAP integrated • consistent routine ⇒ stress

Notable Quotes (Record exact words when possible)

- "I just know this works"
- "Trader Joes is usually as cheap as it gets in my area"
- "If I carry it with me, it's uncomfortable so I want to hurry to get home so I don't overshop"
- "The time to go to save what - 30 cents? It's not worth it"
- "I try to bag between 40 & 50 bucks"
- "Sometimes I can't be bothered to cook - that's what freezer meals are for"

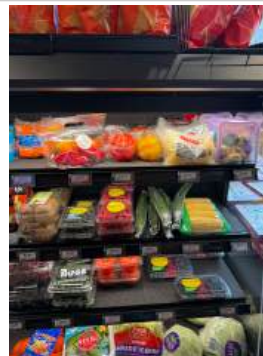
Photos Taken (List description and photo # for reference)



Grocery list on phone before shopping



D bus stop in front of kwik trip



Veg & fruits @ kwik trip



\$4.29 lb / 73 / 27 beef;
\$4.79 lb / 80 / 20 beef
@ kwik trip



D-bus stop @ TJ's



Pasta @ TJ's \$1.29 bags
are enough for a week
most of the time



\$3.99 lb / 48 oz bag of Jasmine
Rice @ TJ's

Post-Session Reflection

Complete immediately after the session while observations are fresh.

Top 3 Insights from this session:

1. Routine Optimized: Participant has engineered a highly stable grocery system that minimizes cognitive load, time cost, & financial risk
2. Physical constraints as behavioral control (carried groceries from lunch trip to TJ's is intentionally used to prevent over spending)
3. SNAP acceptance shapes network of visited grocery stores + transit/walk accessibility

Biggest Surprise:

Surprised by how little variation exists in their system. Despite financial constraints, there was no "constant deal hunting." Instead, they rely on consistency and trust in a tried-and-true routine

Questions for Follow-up / Things to Explore:

- How did this system evolve over time? How long did it take?
- What caused past financial breakdowns?
- Would they use a tool to compare SNAP-eligible store prices?
- How do roommates affect food coordination? Do you all ever mooch off each other?
- Would push notifications about price drops change behavior?

How does this connect to our Focus Objectives?

- 1) How students decide what groceries to buy: meal-first planning model
- 2) Price vs. nutrition vs. convenience → balanced substitute that w/ fallbacks
- 3) SNAP & transit accessibility shaping decisions + integrated into planning
- 4) Workarounds & systems → using physical weight/inconveniences as overspending deterrent & routine (convenience to keep from overspending/leaking out.
- 5) Frequency: Weekly; time spent: 60-90 min

Team Debrief Notes:

Discuss with your partner immediately after the session.

- Routine consistency reduces stress more than deal hunting.
- Optimization is behavioral, not digital
- Physical environment (distance, bus stops, fridge space) is central
- Design opportunity may not be "more information" — it may be helping students systematize like this participant.
- SNAP filtering, cost visualization, and absolute commute time visualizations could be helpful
- Overstimulation in stores is a real friction point.

Remember: Scan/photocopy these notes to include in your final submission!

Contextual Inquiry Field Notes

LIS 470 — Introduction to Interaction Design

Date: March 1st 2016

Time: 2:30 pm

Location: Participant's Apartment

Participant ID: Session

Facilitator: Zanbin Chen

Note Taker: Helena Huang

Activity Being Observed:

Planning for grocery shopping

Observation Notes

Observations (What you see/hear)

Interpretations (What it might mean)

- sits at kitchen table during sessions → less likely to impulsively shopping
- check freezer storage
- Mention usually goes on weekend + plans about 1 week ahead → planner

1 week ahead

- Happy + likes to bring large crossbody bag → like to shop multiple times at once

- Mention prefer Trader Joe's or Target for large quantity shopping (shows shopping history) → have prefer shopping spots, may already have a habit

- highlight small price increases are acceptable if food tastes good, taste matters then more → less likely to be a price sensitive consumer, relate to financial situation not exactly low income.

Areas to Document

Use this section to organize detailed observations across the four areas.

ACTIVITY — What is the participant doing? Describe step-by-step actions, sequence, duration.

- check freezer storage, for around 50 seconds + looks pretty full,
- mention large grocery trip - 1 week in advance + plan with online app, + show app for ~7 minutes.
- check bus routes to Trader Joe / Target, for around 1 min.
- show her large bag for shopping, for around 30 seconds

CONTEXT — Where is this happening? What tools, artifacts, people, environmental factors are present?

- participant's Apartment, her dining hall + kitchen
- her refrigerator
- her phone and laptop to do online research,
- Parental Support makes things less stressful

NEEDS / VALUES — What matters to the participant? What are they trying to achieve?

- Taste!
- Quality consistency
- Time efficiency
- Acceptable price range
- convenience when busy (midterm, finals...)

ASSUMPTIONS — What beliefs or expectations guide their behavior?

- Trader Joe's = better price + better selection (she seems to prefer the brand...)
- Freezing preserves values (tend to buy a lot online)
- if quality drops, produce no longer worth buying

Breakdowns & Successes

BREAKDOWNS

(Frustrations, errors, confusion)

- mentioned abandoned shopping at Whole Food because of high price...
- long trips require significant time as minimum
- too busy to allocate grocery time

SUCCESSSES

(What worked well, satisfaction)

- clear system: large trip + small emergency sup
- shopping bag strategy (reasonable + people help out)
- freezing bulk purchases extend food use

Notable Quotes (Record exact words when possible)

- " Fresh is more expensive "
- " at least 2-4 hours "
- " I'll not buy there if the quality drops "

Photos Taken (List description and photo # for reference)

Attached later

Post-Session Reflection

Complete immediately after the session while observations are fresh.

Top 3 Insights from this session:

1. Time cost savings by contributing to grocery shopping frequency
2. Quality being the No.1 factor in purchasing decisions
3. external support (parents) reduce grocery pressure

Biggest Surprise:

- expected more strategy, but no
- price isn't playing the larger role in making purchasing decisions!

Questions for Follow-up / Things to Explore:

- Would you behave differently if you drove instead of taking the bus?
- how do you decide when/where when you know you have limited carrying capacity?

How does this connect to our Focus Objectives?

- we find food purchasing may not be a conscious process but embedded in routine.
- maybe we may need to redefine what counts as preparation.

Team Debrief Notes:

Discuss with your partner immediately after the session.

- we agree that participants framed behavior as "causal", but actual behavior reveals adaptive systems
- we agreed that transportation constraint is becoming a recurring theme

Remember: Scan/photocopy these notes to include in your final submission!



Fig 1. Participant's freezer, she wants to open it and check the food left from last week.



Fig 2. Participant's freezer is very full



Fig 3. Participant checking past purchase from Target App



Fig 4. Participant browsing through her purchase preference

Contextual Inquiry Field Notes

LIS 470 — Introduction to Interaction Design

Date: <u>February 28, 2026</u>	Time: <u>12:30 P.M.</u>
Location: <u>UW Madison</u>	Participant ID: _____
Facilitator: <u>Angelique Carrillo</u>	Note Taker: <u>Deixin Yang</u>

Activity Being Observed:

UW Madison student planning groceries for the week

Observation Notes

Observations (What you see/hear)	Interpretations (What it might mean)
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- ° opens notes app on laptop → too many open tabs
- ° makes categories ("dairy", "veg.", "snacks", "fruit", etc.) → organization is important
- ° simultaneously opens target website
- ° searches for falafel - Target on State St. does not have it → Not all stores carry same brands
* brand is important *
- ° Target does not have specific "good culture" cottage cheese
- ° participant moves to another site "capital center market"
- ° continues to add spinach, grapes, english muffins, and tomatoes to cart
- ° does NOT buy online, cart is just for reference → seeing everything in one place + an estimated total of price to prepare
- ° roommate asks "can you buy more detergent?" → shared decision making between roommates.

Areas to Document

Use this section to organize detailed observations across the four areas.

ACTIVITY — What is the participant doing? Describe step-by-step actions, sequence, duration.

✓ Total time
34 mins

- | | |
|--|---|
| 1. opens & checks fridge (1 min) | 6. if not changes to new tab & searches fresh ok capital market |
| 2. sits at table w/ laptop | 7. Adds items to cart to make a visual list w/ prices |
| 3. Adds groceries to notes app in categories (5 mins) | 8. ASKS roommates what they collectively needs |
| 4. Searches individual items on target.com | 9. Finalize notes list & send it to mobile phone |
| 5. chooses "pickup" from closest location to ensure its in stock | |

CONTEXT — Where is this happening? What tools, artifacts, people, environmental factors are present?

- small shared kitchen, small refrigerator, not much storage space, 4 roommates
- Fridge contains lot of same products, items, brands (mostly whole foods/organic)
- Laptop (macbook)
- Evening, after classes, night before grocery trip

NEEDS / VALUES — What matters to the participant? What are they trying to achieve?

- Prefers walking distance stores (no car)
- Prefers organic/whole foods
- Goes for low caloric/sugar free options
- Does not buy more than she absolutely needs (avoid overspending, waste, no fridge space)
- Needs to plan same breakfast, dinner, & snack for 4-5 days
- Is okay with making multiple trips (normally does)

ASSUMPTIONS — What beliefs or expectations guide their behavior?

- Target is cheaper while fresh & capital are overpriced
- organic products are more expensive but worth it
- Assumes roommates will share some items (chouli hold)

Breakdowns & Successes

Post-Session Reflection

Complete immediately after the session while observations are fresh.

Top 3 Insights from this session:

1. inventory one ck + price comparison is manual and time consuming
2. grocery shopping is collaborative w/ roommates
3. multi-trip grocery shopping is necessary & anticipated for those w/ strong preferences, and goals.

Biggest Surprise:

The amount of same type products that were in the shared fridge. many times they don't know who's is who's and it gets tossed

Questions for Follow-up / Things to Explore:

- Where did these recipes come from? (meal plans)
- Would you shop at multiple stores if price difference was small?

How does this connect to our Focus Objectives?

- Participant always compares prices
- Nutrition label of product ("organic", "non-fat", "sugar-free", etc.) was actively checked
- No true set budget
- Total time can be significantly reduced

Team Debrief Notes:

Discuss with your partner immediately after the session.

- We should add a collaborative aspect to the app
 - ↳ We are out of X — fast & easy reminders
 - ↳ X just bought X — fast feedback (no one buys 2 of the same)
 - ↳ Venmo X for X — financial efficiency

Remember: Scan/photocopy these notes to include in your final submission!

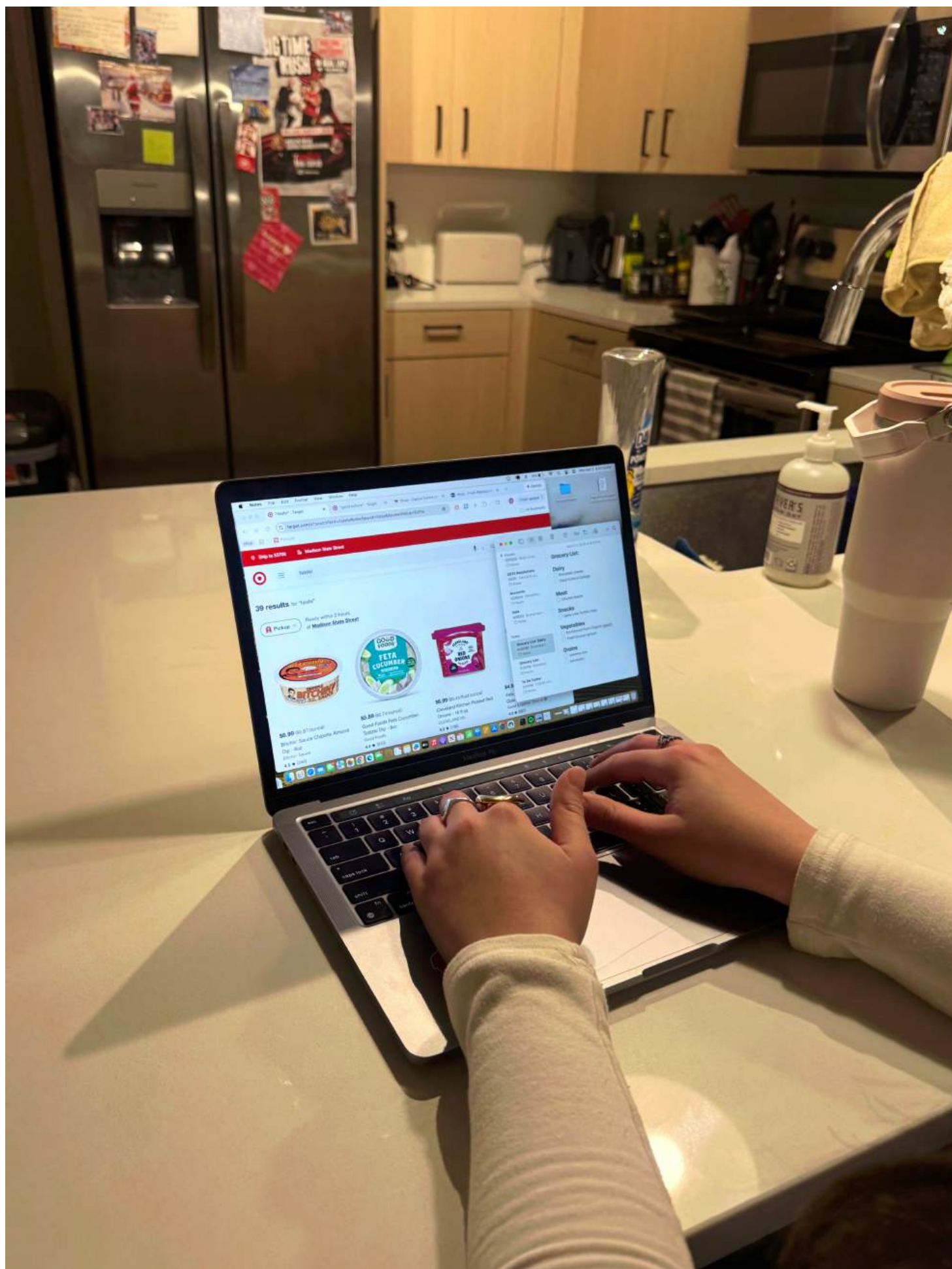
BREAKDOWNS (Frustrations, errors, confusion)	SUCCESSSES (What worked well, satisfaction)
• unable to find desired product • Target deals don't automatically apply • toggling between tabs & windows	• Texting roomates to plan shared items • creating an online grocery list • visualize prices

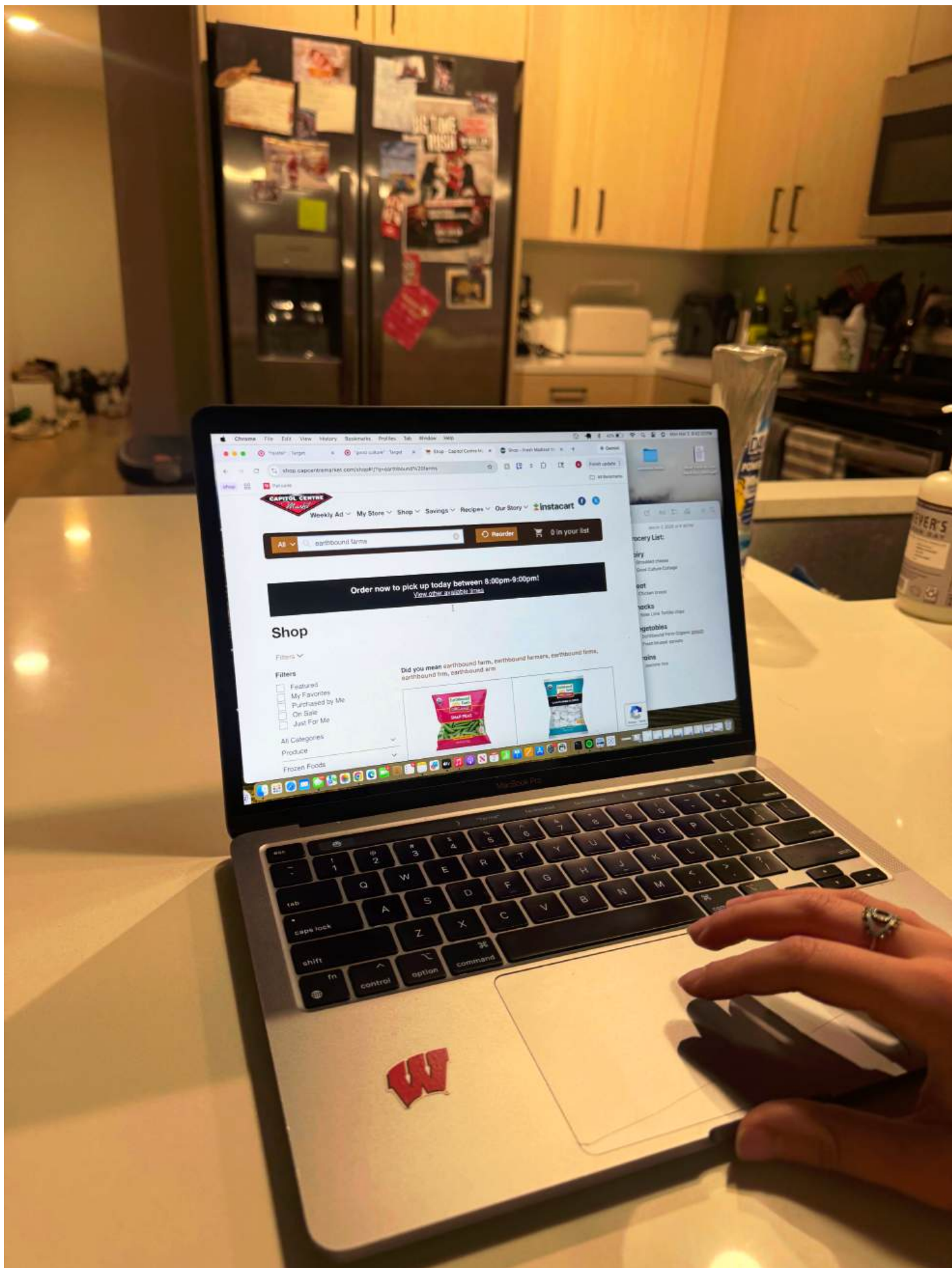
Notable Quotes (Record exact words when possible)

- "We buy a lot of the same stuff"
- "Target on state doesn't sell good culture but I think capital does"
- "I might just get sweet arden tonight since I have nothing"
- "I check capitol today they don't have it" (Good culture cottage cheese out of stock)

Photos Taken (List description and photo # for reference)

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Contextual Inquiry Field Notes

LIS 470 — Introduction to Interaction Design

Date: 2/26/2026 Time: 1:26 p.m.
Location: Student Activities Center, Participant ID: PL Iris
333 University Ave
Facilitator: Helena Huang Note Taker: Yankin Chen

Activity Being Observed: The process of how participants (college students) organize and plan grocery shoppings in their daily life.

Observation Notes

Observations (What you see/hear)

Interpretations (What it might mean)

- International student → financial support from family
- Weather conditions might make her cancel plans (too cold) → convenience is an important factor
- knows about food pantry in UMS but never used it
- will seriously consider about food prices and even compare with ones in her hometown, but not now → change of understanding about price conditions
(new students might still care a lot?)
- "Directly go to stores that are close to me, like Fresh Market."
- Usually go to grocery stores everyday to buy fresh vegetables
- But sometimes she will go to Target to get blueberries. → personal preference
- Basically depends on daily activities → to ~~save~~ time
want the freshest food on a daily basis
- Quality first → Convenience first: Fresh > market around apart
- If prices are the same, she will prefer quality; But if quality is the same, she prefers lower price. price still matters

Areas to Document

Use this section to organize detailed observations across the four areas.

ACTIVITY — What is the participant doing? Describe step-by-step actions, sequence, duration.

1. The participant describes her grocery shopping routines since she really doesn't plan much and does that almost everyday. (3 minutes)
2. Opens the online delivery app on her phone (10 seconds)
3. Shows us the regular things she would buy online and adds them to the shopping cart. It lasts around 2 minutes.
4. Brings us directly to the Fresh Market afterwards to show what her normal trip to the Fresh Market would like. (15 minutes)

CONTEXT — Where is this happening? What tools, artifacts, people, environmental factors are present?

- The main process and conversations happened in the UMS student activity center since that's where the participant preferred for the interview. The environment is quiet with only a few of people talking in the background. The only tool used in this process is the participant's phone.
- She went through her online application of the grocery stores she normally order from and went to the Fresh Market for a quick traverse to showcase.

NEEDS / VALUES — What matters to the participant? What are they trying to achieve?

- The quality of the food matters the most.
- She also tries to integrate her grocery shopping trips into her daily routines for her own convenience.

ASSUMPTIONS — What beliefs or expectations guide their behavior?

- We assume she wants to save time by integrating grocery shopping into her daily activities.

Breakdowns & Successes

BREAKDOWNS

(Frustrations, errors, confusion)

- She stood still and thought about the items she needs to buy today for several times during her trip to the Fresh Market.

SUCCESSSES

(What worked well, satisfaction)

- She smoothly went through the online grocery delivery app and added all the items she buy regularly to the cart since she's really familiar with that.

Notable Quotes (Record exact words when possible)

"I prefer directly going to stores that are close to my daily activity locations, like Fresh Market."

"I've went to all the possible stores around just to find the most delicious blueberries, since I really like blueberries and I want them to be fresh and in high quality."

Photos Taken (List description and photo # for reference)

listed in the photo document.

Post-Session Reflection

Complete immediately after the session while observations are fresh.

Top 3 Insights from this session:

1. Quality (freshness / taste) of the food first
an factor
2. Price is still ^{an} important, but it is not as crucial due to the fact that the participant has sufficient financial support from her family
3. as an International student
The planning part of her grocery shopping experience usually is quite short and happens in the middle of her trips. Her plans are quite flexible

Biggest Surprise:

The participant buys her groceries in-between her daily activities not for the sake of saving time, but because she wants fresh food in daily basis. ^{the most}

Questions for Follow-up / Things to Explore:

Q: Would you prefer the Fresh Market or a store near your home, and why? ^{which has higher quality food}

A: I will still choose the Fresh Market since it's more convenient to go there between my events during the day. The route is just better.

Q: Is there a time that you seriously consider about food prices when you buy groceries?

A: Yes, when I first came to the U.S., I will compare the price of each item with the ones in my country. But I'm more familiar with the price conditions now and wouldn't consider too much if it's not absurdly high.

How does this connect to our Focus Objectives?

College students might also concern with the food qualities, so maybe our app should also include information about the latest restock time of the items.

Team Debrief Notes:

Discuss with your partner immediately after the session.

- International students typically have financial supports from their family, so their focuses might be on the quality of the food.
- Time spend on Transportation to each grocery store is an important factor to be added.

Remember: Scan/photocopy these notes to include in your final submission!

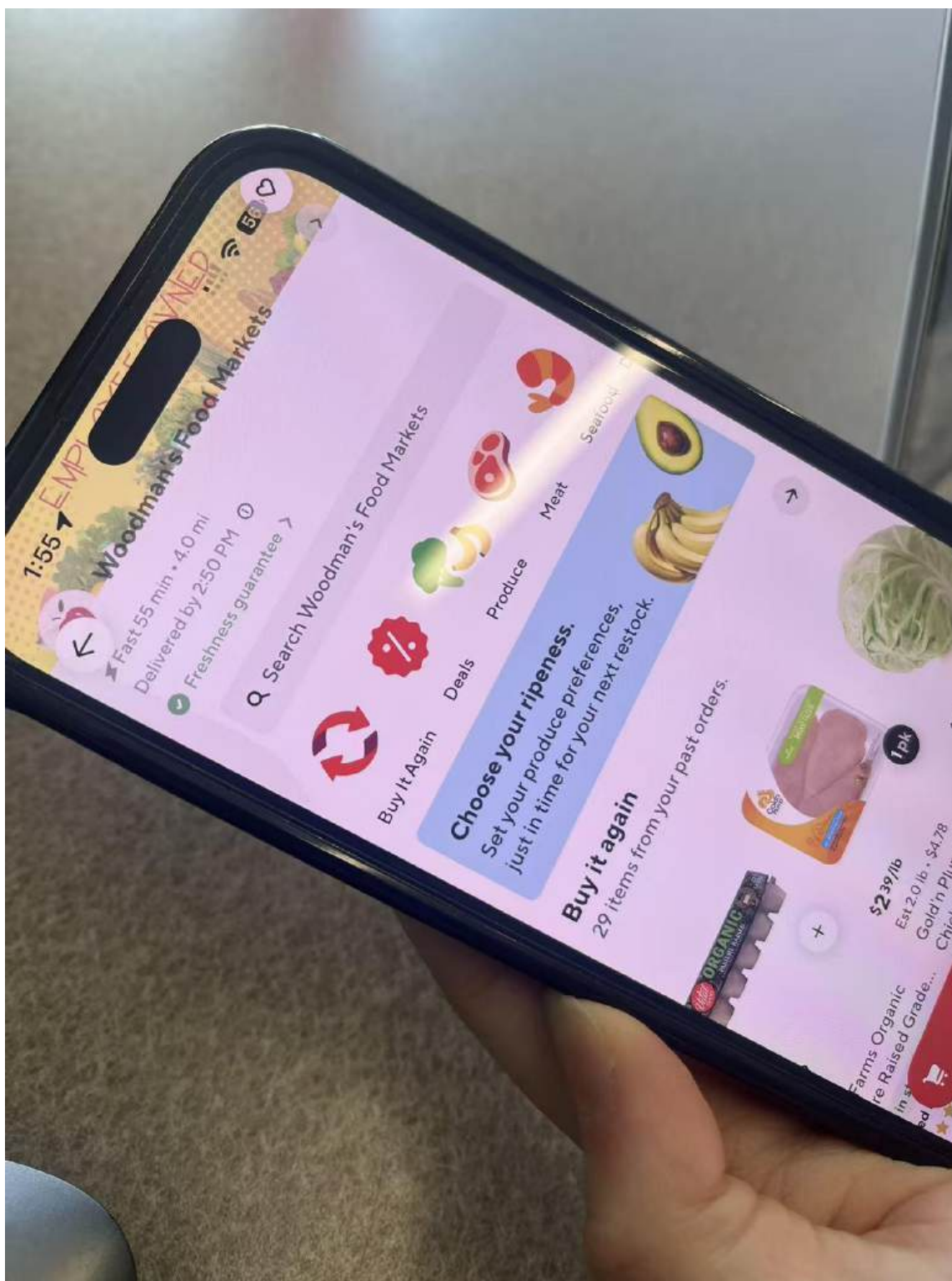


Image 1: The participant shows the food delivery application she normally use for online grocery shopping

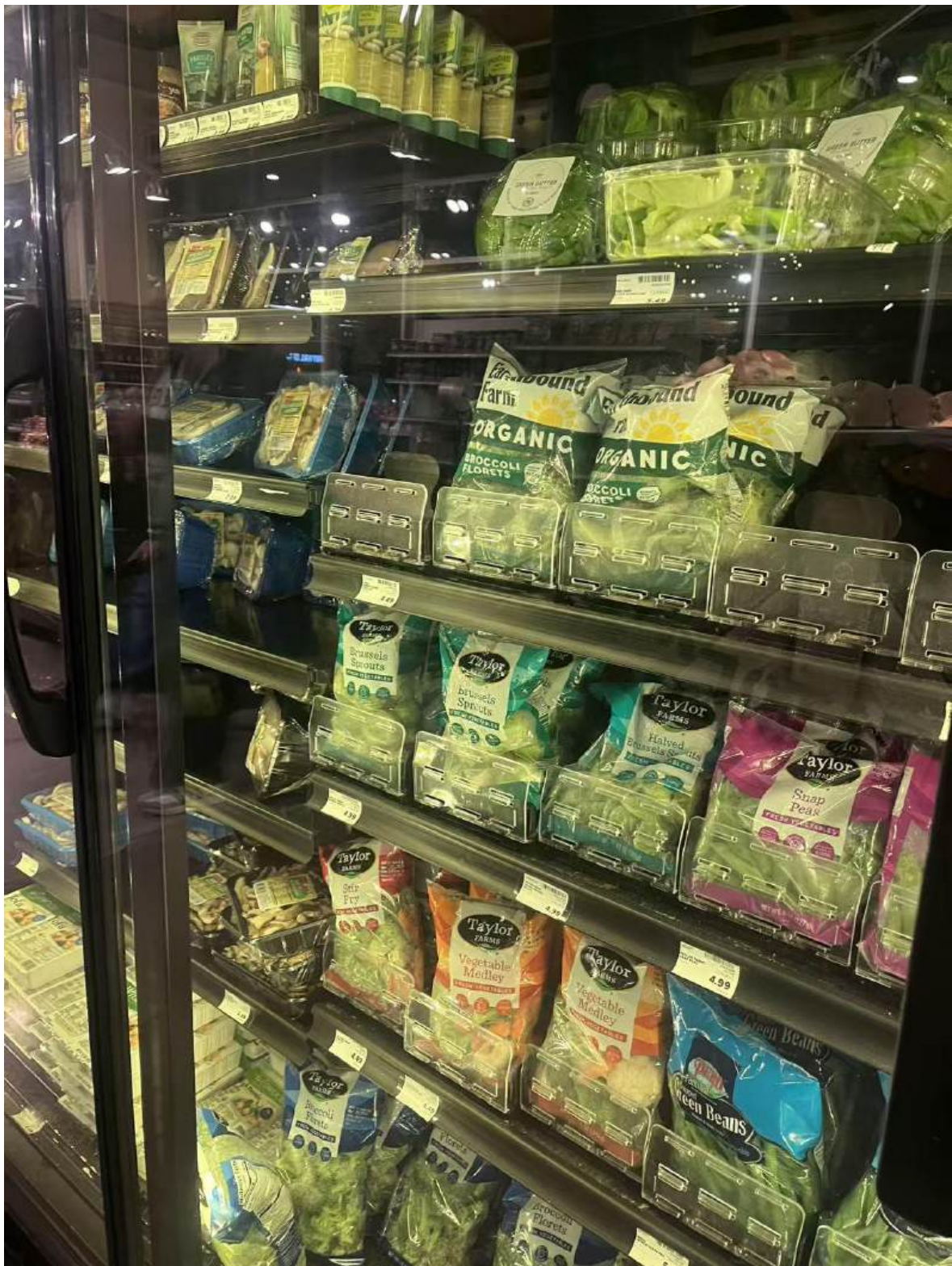


Image 2: The participant shows the items she regularly get in a daily basis in her trip to the Fresh Market



Image 3: The participant gives us example of the food quality she prefer to have when going to grocery stores

Participant: Franky (Graduate Student, lives off campus, no meal plan)

Duration: 38 min

Date: 3/1/2026

Note taker: Peiran Yang

0-5 min

Opens phone; says "I usually just buy the same stuff every week."
Starts listing: eggs, milk, rice, chicken, yogurt...
Seems relaxed.

5-12 min

Opens Target website on laptop → searches "chicken breast".
Long pause (~20s) → scrolling between two options.
Says "This one's cheaper... I'll probably get that."
Comparing price per lb manually.

Observation: Very price sensitive; No tool helping comparison.

12-20 min

Did Not check weekly ads first.
Noticed "Sale" label only after clicking item.
Says "I usually forgot to check sales honestly".
Seems slightly annoyed.

20-30 min

Add items to cart.
Checks subtotal over \$60...
Slightly sigh.
Says "I try to keep it under \$60."
Delete chips + ice cream.
Says "Snacks are the first to go."

Observation:

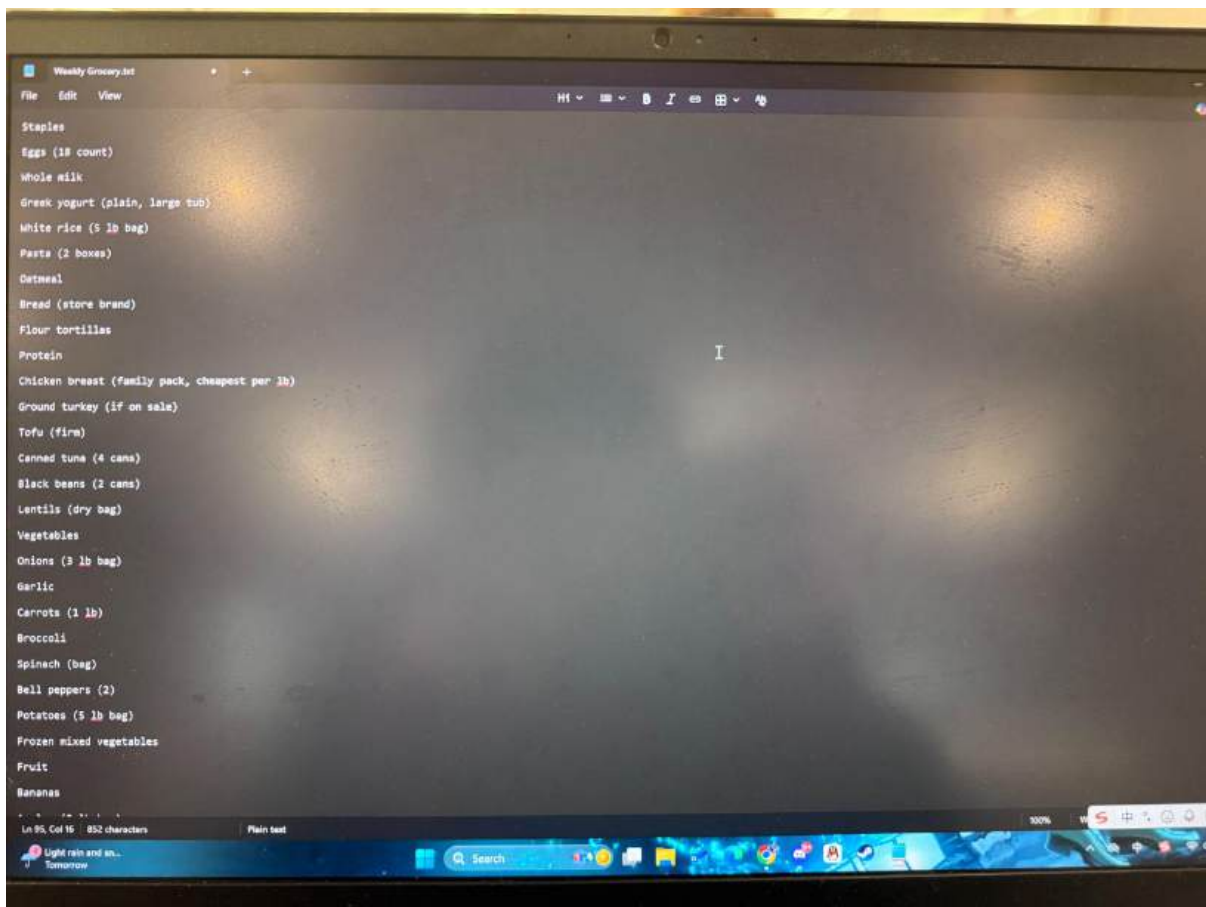
Budget pressure visible.
Makes trade-offs at checkout stage.

30-38 min

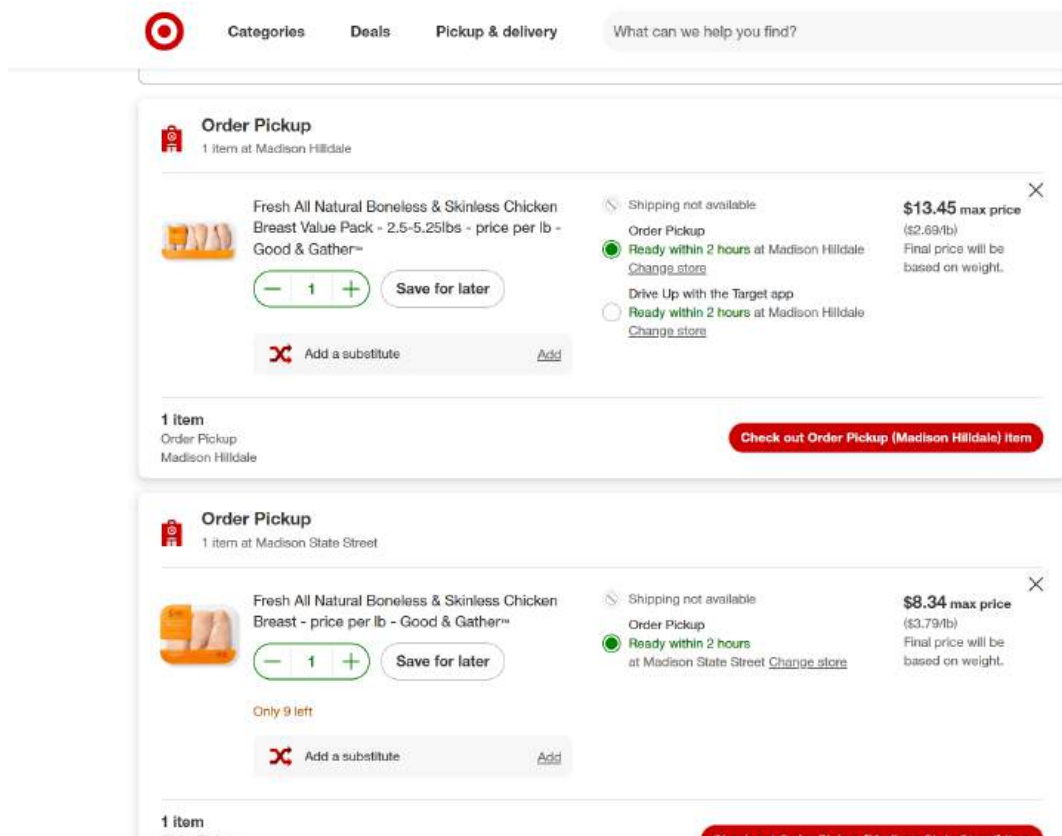
Does mental math, no calculator.
Says: "I just kinda guess most of the time."
No tracking of previous weeks spending.
Seems unsure about final total.

Design opportunity:

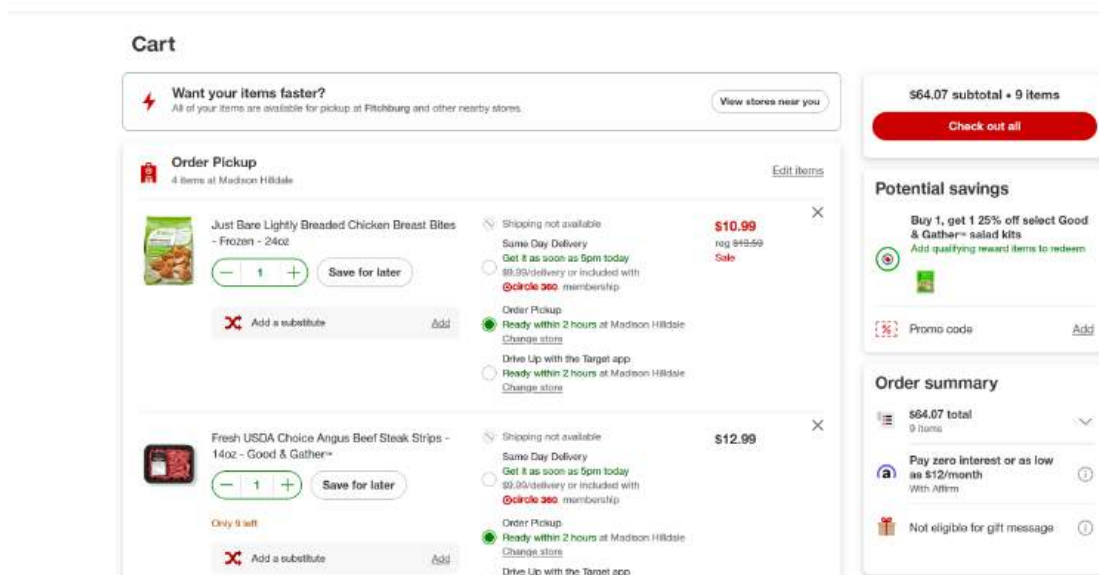
- Real-time budget tracker
- Automatic sale highlights.
- Weekly spending summary.
- Cheaper substitute suggestions.



Participant written list on laptop



Participant Comparing the price of chicken breast.



Participant checking total price